

WORLD RELIGIONS

OVERVIEW

The study of world religions cultivates an understanding of the roles of religion in contemporary society. World religions courses encourage students to explore the ways in which religions and belief traditions meet various human needs and to examine the significance and function of sacred places, rites, writings, and teachings in diverse world religions and belief traditions.

In the two world religions courses in the social sciences and humanities curriculum, students develop their understanding of the connections between religion and social, ethical, and philosophical issues as well as personal psychological needs and concerns. These courses also examine critical issues facing world religions and their adherents today. Research and inquiry skills are developed throughout the courses as students explore and analyse contemporary and historical issues surrounding world religions.

World Religions and Belief Traditions in Daily Life, Grade 11

Open

HRF30

This course enables students to study world religions and belief traditions in local, Canadian, and global contexts. Students will explore aspects of the human quest for meaning and will examine world religions and belief traditions as exemplified in various sacred teachings and principles, rites, and passages. They will also study the interaction throughout history between society and various belief traditions, and will have opportunities to develop research and inquiry skills related to the study of world religions and belief traditions.

Prerequisite: None

A. RESEARCH AND INQUIRY SKILLS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1. Exploring:** explore topics related to world religions and belief traditions, and formulate questions to guide their research;
- A2. Investigating:** create research plans, and locate and select information relevant to their chosen topics, using appropriate social science and humanities research and inquiry methods;
- A3. Processing Information:** assess, record, analyse, and synthesize information gathered through research and inquiry;
- A4. Communicating and Reflecting:** communicate the results of their research and inquiry clearly and effectively, and reflect on and evaluate their research, inquiry, and communication skills.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

A1. Exploring

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1.1** explore a variety of topics related to world religions and belief traditions (*e.g., rites of passage, religious observances*) to identify topics for research and inquiry
- A1.2** identify key concepts (*e.g., through discussion, brainstorming, use of visual organizers*) related to their selected topics
- A1.3** formulate effective questions to guide their research and inquiry
Teacher prompt: “If you were researching rites of passage in different communities, what might be the advantage of comparing religious rites of passage to those based on secular traditions?”

A2. Investigating

Throughout this course, students will:

- A2.1** create appropriate research plans to investigate their selected topics (*e.g., outline purpose and method; identify sources of information*), ensuring that their plans follow guidelines for ethical research
Teacher prompts: “What are some ways to locate reliable sources of information?” “How might you determine whether your

research requires you to consult both primary and secondary sources or allows you to rely exclusively on secondary sources?”

- A2.2** locate and select information relevant to their investigations from a variety of primary sources (*e.g., interviews, observations, surveys, questionnaires, original documents in print or other media – film, photographs, songs, advertisements, sacred texts*) and/or secondary sources (*e.g., book reviews, textbooks, websites, brochures, newspaper articles*)
- A2.3** based on preliminary research, for each investigation formulate a research question and identify potential subtopics to focus their research

A3. Processing Information

Throughout this course, students will:

- A3.1** assess various aspects of information gathered from primary and secondary sources (*e.g., accuracy, relevance, reliability, inherent values and bias, voice*)
Teacher prompts: “What strategies can you use to determine the relevance of the information you have gathered?” “If two information sources contradict each other, how might you determine which is more reliable?” “What values are embedded in the information sources?” “Whose voices are represented

and whose are absent?" "Whose interests are advanced if you believe the main message of this source?"

A3.2 record and organize information and key ideas using a variety of formats (*e.g., notes, graphic organizers, summaries, audio/digital records*)

A3.3 analyse and interpret research information (*e.g., determine whether common themes arise in different sources*)

A3.4 demonstrate academic honesty by documenting the sources of all information generated through research

A3.5 synthesize findings and formulate conclusions (*e.g., weigh and connect information to determine the answer to their research questions*)

A4. Communicating and Reflecting

Throughout this course, students will:

A4.1 use an appropriate format (*e.g., oral presentation, formal debate, poster, multimedia presentation, web page*) to communicate the results of their research and inquiry effectively for a specific purpose and audience

A4.2 use terms relating to world religions and belief traditions correctly (*e.g., belief, creed, custom, deity, divine, faith, habit, mysticism, profane, sacred*)

A4.3 clearly communicate the results of their inquiries (*e.g., write clearly, organize ideas logically, use language conventions properly*), and follow appropriate conventions for acknowledging sources (*e.g., MLA, Chicago, or Turabian-style references and/or notes*)

A4.4 demonstrate an understanding of the general research process by reflecting on and evaluating their own research, inquiry, and communication skills

Teacher prompts: "What steps might you take to enhance your research/inquiry skills?" "What questions arise from the results of your research?"

B. COMMONALITIES, CONCEPTS, AND CONTEXTS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1. Commonalities:** demonstrate an understanding of the commonalities among various world religions and belief traditions that coexist within a diverse society;
- B2. Terms and Concepts:** define and appropriately use terms and concepts related to world religions and belief traditions, examining their meaning in the context of various beliefs;
- B3. Global and Local Contexts:** demonstrate an understanding of global and local contexts in which world religions and belief traditions function.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

B1. Commonalities

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1.1** explain how common human needs (*e.g., for a sense of community and identity, a moral code, a sense of purpose or meaning, ritual*) are reflected in religions and belief traditions across cultures and historical eras

Teacher prompt: “In what ways do religious institutions seek to continue to be relevant in today’s increasingly secular society?”

- B1.2** evaluate the importance of celebrations and commemorations in human experience (*e.g., anniversaries, birthdays, historical markers*)

Teacher prompts: “Why is it important to celebrate special moments?” “Why might human milestones be seen as an expression of the divine?” “What are some ways in which people commemorate significant events or moments (*e.g., with flowers, photographs*)?” “Why would a community want to name a library, airport, school, or public place after an individual?”

- B1.3** identify various world religions and belief traditions that coexist within a diverse society, and explain why it is important to learn about them

Teacher prompts: “How might the way a person dresses or eats reflect his or her belief tradition?” “Why is it important for us to understand why our friends, neighbours, or

co-workers are celebrating, fasting, or praying at certain times?” “What is secular humanism and why is it important to understand secular humanism in discussions of world religions?”

- B1.4** explain how a focus on the differences between various religions rather than their commonalities can foster prejudice, bias, and discrimination

Teacher prompts: “Why are the terms *cult* and *idolatry* problematic?” “What are some negative consequences that can result from a focus on the differences between faith communities (*e.g., the growth of prejudice, bias, and antipathy leading to wars of religion or the persecution/oppression of minority groups*)?”

B2. Terms and Concepts

By the end of this course, students will:

- B2.1** define and appropriately use terms and concepts related to the study of world religions and belief traditions (*e.g., agnosticism, atheism, belief, clergy, conservative, creed, cult, custom, deity, denomination, divine, ecumenism, faith, fundamentalism, habit, interfaith dialogue, laity, liberal, monotheism, mysticism, orthodoxy, pantheism, polytheism, profane, reform, ritual, sacred, secular, supernatural, tradition*)

- B2.2** explain the perceived nature and role of the supernatural and the divine in various religions and belief traditions

Teacher prompts: “What are some ways in which various belief traditions regard life and death and the role of humanity and divinity in the world? What are some reasons for any differences between their views?” “How is the supernatural viewed in secular humanism?”

B3. Global and Local Contexts

By the end of this course, students will:

B3.1 describe factors that contribute or have contributed to the global influence of various religions and belief traditions (*e.g., emigration and immigration, forced migration through enslaved labour, proselytism, colonialism*)

Teacher prompts: “How has immigration changed Canadian understandings of and attitudes regarding various belief traditions?” “Why might a person choose to convert from one belief tradition to another?”

B3.2 analyse ways in which religions and belief traditions can influence the relationship between individuals and their society, with a focus on contemporary Canadian society

Teacher prompt: “Under what circumstances might it be acceptable for an employee to refuse to do something that conflicts with the teachings of his or her belief tradition?”

B3.3 explain the impact of including “creed” as a protected ground of discrimination under the Ontario Human Rights Code

B3.4 explain how individual religious beliefs can affect the ways in which people relate to others

Teacher prompts: “How might a friend’s religious beliefs and practices influence your relationship?” “How did Mother Teresa’s actions express her religious beliefs?”

B3.5 identify similarities between civil and religious observances and celebrations (*e.g., the oath of citizenship, the national anthem, Remembrance Day*)

Teacher prompts: “Why is November 11 a significant day for most Western countries? How do we recognize its significance?” “Why do schools play ‘O Canada’ every morning?” “Why are there many Christian symbols and references at civil ceremonies in Canada? What does the presence of religious tokens and symbols at civil ceremonies indicate about human responses to such things as war, death, citizenship, and patriotism?”

C. COMMUNITY WITHIN SACRED AND SECULAR CONTEXTS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1. Historical Contexts:** demonstrate an understanding of the historical contexts that have shaped particular religions and belief traditions;
- C2. Community Beliefs and Practices:** demonstrate an understanding of various ways in which adherents of particular world religions and belief traditions relate to their own and other communities;
- C3. Belief Traditions and Popular Culture:** demonstrate an understanding of ways in which various world religions and belief traditions are interpreted and adapted within popular culture.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

C1. Historical Contexts

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1.1** identify and describe significant episodes from the history of various world religions and belief traditions

Teacher prompts: “How has the experience of diaspora affected the practices of Judaism?” “Why is the founding of the Confederacy of Six Nations an important event in Haudenosaunee history?” “Why would the opening of the Woodlands Cultural Centre be a significant event for the Confederacy of Six Nations?” “What is the tradition of leadership succession in Tibetan Buddhism? How might this tradition be affected by the fourteenth Dalai Lama’s experience of exile?”

- C1.2** identify major figures from the history of various world religions and belief traditions, and explain their origins, roles, and contributions

Teacher prompts: “How did Baha’ullah contribute to and influence the Baha’i faith?” “How have the Haudenosaunee been influenced by those born outside their nation, such as Peacemaker?” “How does the significance and role of Jesus of Nazareth differ in Christianity and Islam?”

- C1.3** explain the relationship between specific historical incidents and the practices or rituals associated with particular belief traditions (e.g., the exodus of Jews from Egypt and the eating of matzo at Passover)

- C1.4** explain the relationship between religious movements (e.g., Reform Judaism) or events (e.g., the Second Vatican Council) and changes in religious practice over time

Teacher prompts: “Why has there been a decrease in the number of people entering vowed religious communities and an increase in lay movements and participation within the Roman Catholic tradition since the Second Vatican Council?”

C2. Community Beliefs and Practices

By the end of this course, students will:

- C2.1** identify and explain differences in beliefs and belief-related practices between different branches within particular communities of believers, and describe unifying elements that connect them despite their differences

Teacher prompts: “Why is the Dalai Lama differently perceived by Vajrayana, Theravada, and Mahayana Buddhists, as well as different groups within secular society?” “How does the concept of *umma* influence relationships between Shia, Sunni, and Ismaili Muslims?”

- C2.2** describe various roles played by people in different belief traditions (e.g., senators in the Métis tradition; the laity in Orthodox Christianity; the cantor in Jewish Sabbath services; men and women, boys and girls in various traditions)

C2.3 demonstrate an understanding of how various world religions and belief traditions accommodate a range of commitment, from strict observance to liberal compromise

Teacher prompts: “How do Old Order Amish differ from Conservative Mennonites?” “Why may Hindus express their devotion in a multiplicity of ways?”

C2.4 describe difficulties that individuals may encounter in Canadian society when their religious observance includes particular practices in regard to dress, diet, or behaviour (e.g., *wearing hijab, refusing blood transfusions, following a vegetarian diet, offering tobacco*)

C3. Belief Traditions and Popular Culture

By the end of this course, students will:

C3.1 describe ways in which popular culture uses traditional symbols, ideas, and other elements associated with various world religions and belief traditions

Teacher prompts: “How does a Hindu’s view of yoga as a religious discipline differ from the view of yoga projected by the fitness industry?” “How did the Beatles influence the perception of Hinduism in Western culture?” “How do views of marriage in popular culture differ from how marriage is understood by various belief traditions?” “How does the commercialization of tobacco use in popular culture conflict with the sacred role of tobacco in First Nation traditions?” “How appropriate is it for martial arts to be taught without spiritual instruction?”

C3.2 explain the effects on faith communities as well as popular culture when specific faith symbols are appropriated by popular culture

Teacher prompts: “What are some possible effects of the development of sports hijabs? To what extent would it be problematic if sports hijabs were marketed as mainstream sports-wear to keep long hair contained?” “What are some possible effects of the adoption of the traditional Palestinian kuffiyeh as a fashion accessory?”

C3.3 identify, explain, and evaluate examples of bias and prejudice in pop-culture representations of religions and belief traditions (e.g., *depictions of Hinduism in The Simpsons; representations of Islam in the media*)

D. ACTIONS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1. Festivals, Celebrations, and Commemorations:** demonstrate an understanding of the role and significance of festivals, celebrations, and commemorations in various world religions and belief traditions;
- D2. Rites of Passage:** describe the role and significance of rites of passage in various world religions and belief traditions;
- D3. Daily Observances:** describe and explain the function and significance of the daily observances practised by followers of various world religions and belief traditions.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

D1. Festivals, Celebrations, and Commemorations

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1.1** explain the significance of major festivals and other commemorations in various world religions and belief traditions

Teacher prompt: “Why would some Jewish people say that Yom Kippur is the most holy day in the Jewish calendar?”

- D1.2** identify and describe the observances and practices associated with the major festivals, commemorations, and celebrations of various world religions and belief traditions (*e.g., coloured water at Holi, dancing at powwows, lighting candles at the beginning of Shabbat, nativity scenes at Christmas*)

Teacher prompts: “Why are lights and candles an important symbol for the celebration of Wesak by Buddhists?” “Why is drumming often a significant feature in the festivals of indigenous people in Canada and around the world?”

- D1.3** describe the role and significance of fasts and feasts in various belief traditions

Teacher prompts: “Why do Muslims fast during Ramadan?” “Why do Hindus exchange sweets during Holi?” “How does the nalukataq – the spring whaling festival – express the significance of the whale to the Inuit community?”

- D1.4** explain how practices and rituals employed in festivals and celebrations of various religions and belief traditions reflect the teachings of those traditions

Teacher prompts: “How does Ayambil relate to the spiritual goals of a Jain?” “Why is the kiss of peace symbolic of the life of a Christian?” “How does the redistribution of goods in a potlatch express the importance of community interdependence?”

- D1.5** explain the origins of symbols associated with specific religious festivals, celebrations, and commemorations (*e.g., Advent wreath, menorah, lotus, fireworks, sweetgrass*)

Teacher prompts: “What is the significance of the dreidel?” “Explain why fireworks and lights are common symbols associated with the Hindu festival of Diwali.”

D2. Rites of Passage

By the end of this course, students will:

- D2.1** identify and explain the purpose of key rites of passage in various world religions and belief traditions (*e.g., rituals associated with death, marriage, naming a child*)

Teacher prompts: “Why is the naming ceremony such a significant aspect of First Nation, Hindu, Jewish, and Muslim traditions?” “What is the significance of the one-month celebration for infants in Buddhist and Taoist traditions?”

D2.2 describe the practices and rituals employed in specific rites of passage associated with various religions and belief traditions, and explain their significance

Teacher prompts: “Why is candy thrown at the bar mitzvah boy as he completes his Haftorah?” “How do the rituals employed by Hindus in the cremation of the body after death reflect their understanding of the afterlife?” “What are some similarities and differences in the birth, coming of age, and death rituals of several belief traditions?”

D2.3 demonstrate an understanding of symbols, art, and literature associated with rites of passage in various religions and belief traditions

Teacher prompts: “How does He Qi’s painting *The Baptism of Jesus* reveal the importance of baptism to Christians?” “What is the symbolic significance of the tallith in the bar/bat mitzvah?” “How do the symbols of the amritsanchar ceremony represent the expectations of the Sikh who joins the Khalsa?” “How do the symbols woven into the dream catcher for newborn Ojibwe babies convey the values of the community?”

D3.2 describe the role and significance of daily observances in different world religions and belief traditions (e.g., *Kusti prayers*, *Salah*, *Shema*, *sunrise ceremony*, *the Five Ks in Sikhism*)

Teacher prompts: “How is the Shema observed through both clothing and ritual?” “How might the observation of the sunrise ceremony affect and reflect an individual’s attitude towards the natural world?”

D3.3 explain how daily practices and rituals associated with various religions and belief traditions connect to and/or affect the lives of their adherents

Teacher prompts: “How does the observance of giving thanks (saying ‘grace’) before and after meals anchor and regulate a believer’s day?” “How might the life of someone be affected if he or she spent time in meditation or prayer or in the natural world each day?” “How might a Sikh who observes the Five Ks as a way of life encounter tensions in a secular world that is not informed about the significance of these practices?”

D3. Daily Observances

By the end of this course, students will:

D3.1 identify daily rituals of various world religions and belief traditions (e.g., *regular prayer*, *ritual bathing*, *meditation*)

E. SACRED STORIES AND WRITINGS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- E1. Role of Sacred Writings, Oral Teachings, and Stories:** demonstrate an understanding of the role of sacred writings, oral teachings, and stories in various world religions and belief traditions;
- E2. Influence of Sacred Writings, Oral Teachings, and Stories:** demonstrate an understanding of the influence of sacred writings, oral teachings, and stories on the development of belief and action.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

E1. Role of Sacred Writings, Oral Teachings, and Stories

By the end of this course, students will:

- E1.1** compare and contrast sacred writings and oral teachings
- E1.2** describe the importance of sacred writings and oral teachings in various world religions and belief traditions
- E1.3** describe various sacred writings and oral teachings, providing specific examples from various world religions and belief traditions (e.g., *the Bhagavad Gita*, *the Great Law of Peace of the Longhouse People*, *the Qur'an*, *the Jatakas*, *the Kojiki*, *the Mishnah*, *the New Testament*)

Teacher prompts: “How is the Rig Veda different from the Mahabharata?” “How do the primary sacred texts of Christianity differ from those of Judaism?” “Why is the Haienwtha Belt (wampum belt) categorized by some as both a form of sacred writing and an oral teaching?”

- E1.4** explain the intended message of specific passages from sacred writings or oral teachings from various religions and belief traditions (e.g., *the Beatitudes*, *the Eightfold Path*, *the Seven Grandfather Teachings*)

Teacher prompts: “How would your life change if you were to try to live according to the Seven Grandfather Teachings?” “What kinds of values are reflected in the Beatitudes?” “Why is the Eightfold Path a central tenet of Buddhism?”

E2. Influence of Sacred Writings, Oral Teachings, and Stories

By the end of this course, students will:

- E2.1** explain the influence of sacred writings and oral teachings in the origin and development of various world religions and/or belief traditions (e.g., *the Code of Handsome Lake*, *the Qur'an*, *the New Testament*, *the Tripitaka*)

Teacher prompts: “What do we know about the circumstances that influenced the development of the Code of Handsome Lake?” “How did the manner in which the Qur'an was revealed influence the development of Islam?” “How are the conditions of the early Christian communities reflected in the letters of Paul?”

- E2.2** identify key precepts (e.g., *the Golden Rule*) derived from the sacred writings and oral teachings of various world religions and belief traditions and describe any commonalities

Teacher prompt: “What similarities do you see between the Code of Handsome Lake and the Golden Rule?”

- E2.3** explain the connections between the sacred stories and writings of various world religions and belief traditions and their festivals, celebrations, rites of passage, and daily observances (e.g., *the Book of Esther and Purim*, *the Ramayana and Diwali*, *the Haudenosaunee creation story and the Green Corn Festival*)

Teacher prompts: “How are the events of the Book of Esther reflected in the rituals of Purim?” “How are aspects of the story of Sita’s abduction reflected in the observances of Diwali?”

E2.4 explain the relationships between sacred stories and various symbols and works of art, music, or literature

Teacher prompts: “Why might Bill Reid have chosen each of the figures that were included in the sculpture *Spirit of Haida Gwaii*?” “How accurately do paintings of the Last Supper depict the events described in the Gospel narratives?” “How do differing representations of Hindu deities reflect sacred stories?”

F. DIMENSIONS OF THE SACRED

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- F1. Sacred Time:** demonstrate an understanding of how concepts of time influence the teachings and practices of various world religions and belief traditions;
- F2. Sacred Place:** demonstrate an understanding of how concepts of place influence the teachings and practices of various world religions and belief traditions.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

F1. Sacred Time

By the end of this course, students will:

- F1.1** describe ways in which common celebrations and commemorations associated with various religions and/or belief traditions are linked to concepts of time

Teacher prompts: “What is the connection between respect for ancestors and the arrival of spring through the Qingming festival for Confucians?” “Based on what you know about the potlatch celebration, why would it make more sense to celebrate a potlatch during the winter months rather than the summer months?”

- F1.2** identify and explain the significance of historical events and natural cycles that are commemorated in various religions and belief traditions (e.g., *planting and harvest time; the migrations of monarch butterflies, salmon, and birds; cycles of the moon and sun; the births and/or deaths of religious leaders*)

Teacher prompts: “How does the lunar cycle affect the timing of events in the religious year of various belief traditions? How does its influence compare with the effect of the solar cycle in various belief traditions?” “Why do some communities gather to celebrate cycles of nature?”

F2. Sacred Place

By the end of this course, students will:

- F2.1** describe the main features of the places of worship of various religions or belief traditions

Teacher prompts: “How might the interior features of Roman Catholic churches differ from those of the Eastern Orthodox or Calvinist Reform traditions?” “How does the construction of a sweat lodge reflect the understandings and beliefs of First Nation people about the natural world?” “Why are prayer wheels incorporated into the design of some Buddhist temples?”

- F2.2** explain ways in which attitudes and actions of believers are shaped by convictions about the significance of place (e.g., *places such as Turtle Island for the Haudenosaunee people, the Western Wall for Jews, the Ganges River for Hindus*)

Teacher prompts: “Why is the Ark of the Covenant in a synagogue placed on the side that faces Jerusalem?” “How do adherents of various traditions express reverence when they approach or enter sites of sacred importance?” “How are Aboriginal people’s attitudes towards the environment and the earth a reflection of their larger belief tradition?” “How does the positioning of the Guru Granth Sahib in relation to the congregation in a Gurdwara reflect attitudes about the significance of place?”

- F2.3** identify the relationship between place and common celebrations and commemorations (e.g., *cenotaphs on Remembrance Day*)

Teacher prompts: “Why were veterans upset when the French government wanted to remove a British war cemetery on the Somme battlefield to build an airport?” “Why were the Stoney Point Ojibwe protesting at Ipperwash Provincial Park in 1995?”

F2.4 identify various sacred places that are destinations for pilgrims (*e.g., Jerusalem, Mecca, Varanasi*) and explain the difference between a pilgrimage (*e.g., the hajj*) and other types of spiritual journey (*e.g., the vision quest*)

Teacher prompts: “Why has Jerusalem been a focal point of pilgrimage?” “How do pilgrims to Varanasi express reverence?” “Why is there no specific place that a First Nation male must visit during his vision quest?”